

CST – Holiness When No One’s Looking

Holiness means running away from what others explain away. Joseph understood that sin isn’t just breaking rules—it’s breaking God’s heart. He chose obedience over opportunity, even though it cost him his reputation and his freedom.

Reflection:

What guardrails (boundaries, habits, or people) help protect your integrity when temptation keeps coming “day after day”?

Bite 3 — From Prison to Palace, Gen 41:15-16, 37-39

¹⁵ Pharaoh said to Joseph, “I have dreamed a dream, and there is no one who can interpret it. I have heard it said of you, that when you hear a dream you can interpret it.”¹⁶ Joseph answered Pharaoh, saying, ‘It isn’t in me. God will give Pharaoh an answer of peace.’

³⁷ The thing was good in the eyes of Pharaoh, and in the eyes of all his servants. ³⁸ Pharaoh said to his servants, “Can we find such a one as this, a man in whom is the Spirit of God?” ³⁹ Pharaoh said to Joseph, “Because God has shown you all of this, there is no one so discreet and wise as you.

In one day, Joseph went from prisoner to prime minister—but he made sure the glory went to God, not himself. God was preparing Joseph in places people forgot about: the pit and the prison. Those “wasted years” became his training ground in leadership, humility, and dependence on God. When the door finally opened, Joseph was ready—not because he was perfect, but because he stayed faithful.

Reflection:

Where do you feel “hidden” or overlooked right now? How might God be quietly preparing you for your next assignment?

Dessert — Faith Rewarded, Gen 42:5-6

⁵ The sons of Israel came to buy among those who came, for the famine was in the land of Canaan. ⁶ Joseph was the governor over the land. It was he who sold to all the people of the land. Joseph’s brothers came, and bowed themselves down to him with their faces to the earth.

The vision came to pass. His brothers did in fact bow before him, as he served in a position of authority just below Pharaoh. Even though they thought it would be a bad thing, Jehovah Jireh – the God who supplies, used their younger brother to prevent their starvation and preserve their survival! Their rejection of him propelled him into the position of savior for a region.

To-Go Box

- The **pit**, the **prison**, and the **palace** were all part of Joseph’s training, not random pain.
- Betrayal couldn’t block God’s plan; it became the bridge God used to move Joseph into position.
- Integrity in hidden places prepared Joseph to carry influence in public places.
- God’s promotion often comes suddenly, but the preparation is usually slow and silent.
- What God speaks in a dream, He will fulfill in His time—our job is to stay faithful “through,” not just shout about the promise at the start.

Closing Prayer

“Lord God, thank You for the story of Joseph and for reminding us that You are working even when life feels unfair. Help us to trust You in the pit, to walk in integrity when no one is watching, and to stay faithful in seasons where we feel forgotten. Strengthen our faith to believe that Your promises will come to pass in Your perfect timing. In Jesus’ name, amen.”

Reflection Questions

1. Where do you see yourself in Joseph’s journey right now—pit, prison, palace, or somewhere in between?

2. Write down one promise, dream, or calling from God that you refuse to give up on, even if it seems delayed.

Activity – Fill in the Blank

1. Joseph’s brothers sold him for _____ pieces of silver.
2. Joseph resisted the temptation of _____.
3. Pharaoh said Joseph was filled with the _____ of God.
4. Joseph’s brothers bowed before him in _____.

(Check the Appendix for answers)

 Notes Page — Group Discussion & Personal Study

BM2 — Lesson 2: Hannah

Barren but Not Lifeless

 **Theme:** Prayer in the Pain

 **Background Text:** 1 Samuel 1–2

 **Key Verse:** 1 Samuel 1:27 (WEB)

“I prayed for this child, and Yahweh has given me my petition which I asked of him.”

Introduction

Elkanah was a Jewish man with two wives. In that culture, although love was part of why you married, having children was a major factor. Many times, barren women ended up divorced or pushed to the margins of society. Peninnah and Hannah were his wives, but Hannah could not have children.

Have you ever felt like you were “stuck” in someone else’s shadow? Like no matter what you did, the other person always seemed to be one step ahead? That was Hannah’s situation. Year after year, she was humiliated and reminded how much of a “failure” she was as a wife because she could not give Elkanah an heir.

At least her husband loved her, right? It didn’t feel that way. The voice of her tormentor cut deeply, and it seemed as if her prayers were bouncing off the ceiling.

Appetizer – The Weight of Waiting, 1 Sam 1:7–8

“So year by year, when she went up to Yahweh’s house, her rival provoked her; therefore she wept, and didn’t eat. Elkanah her husband said to her, ‘Hannah, why do you weep? Why don’t you eat? Why is your heart grieved? Am I not better to you than ten sons?’”

In Jewish culture, having children is everything. If a man did not have a child, even if he was a scholar, he was not given the same honor. Their cultural and ethnic code weighed heavily on Hannah’s mind. Her husband had every right, culturally, to divorce her and marry someone else. Inheritance and family legacy were tied to children.

In today’s terms, Hannah showed signs of deep depression and grief. She felt that no one around her really understood or could comfort her. She stopped eating, cried endlessly, and felt useless.

If you or someone you know is going through something similar, there is help available. You do not have to battle alone—reach out to your church family, a community counselor, or a trusted friend.

□ **CST: Desperation can drive determination.**

How does persistent prayer reshape hopelessness into hope?

Main Course

Bite 1 – Provoked but Persistent, 1 Sam 1:9–11

⁹ So Hannah rose up after they had finished eating and drinking in Shiloh. Now Eli the priest was sitting on his seat by the doorpost of Yahweh’s temple. ¹⁰ She was in bitterness of soul, and prayed to Yahweh, weeping bitterly. ¹¹ She vowed a vow, and said, “Yahweh of Armies, if you will indeed look at the affliction of your servant and remember me, and not forget your servant, but will give to your servant a boy, then I will give him to Yahweh all the days of his life, and no razor shall come on his head.”

What do you do when you are really going through it? Who is the best person to turn to who can *truly* help? Many times, we go first to people who can listen—but cannot change anything. Hannah’s womb was “lifeless,” but she took her lifelessness to the Living God.

□ **CST: Pulse Check**

Take a moment to write a prayer request—personal or for your family—that you want the Lord to work out.

Bite 2 – Misunderstood but Heard, 1 Sam 1:12–15

As she continued praying before Yahweh, Eli observed her mouth. Now Hannah spoke in her heart; only her lips moved, but her voice was not heard. Therefore Eli thought she was drunk. Eli said to her, ‘How long will you be drunk? Get rid of your wine!’ Hannah answered, ‘No, my lord, I am a woman of a sorrowful spirit. I have drunk neither wine nor strong drink, but I poured out my soul before Yahweh.’

When you are at your lowest, even “religious” people might misjudge your struggle. But Hannah didn’t let a man’s mistake stop her from talking to her Maker. God hears the prayers that are too deep for words. God is our Promise

Keeper, but sometimes *we* make promises to Him and then break them. If that has ever happened in your life, be honest with God.

Reflections:

Why is it important that we take these acts seriously? Can you think of examples of when people give or make vows (marriage, baptism, oaths, commitments)?

Bite 3 – Promise Given, Promise Kept, 1 Sam 1:16–18, 20

¹⁶“Don’t consider your servant a wicked woman; for I have been speaking out of the abundance of my complaint and my provocation.” ¹⁷Then Eli answered, “Go in peace; and may the God^[a] of Israel grant your petition that you have asked of him.” ¹⁸She said, “Let your servant find favor in your sight.” So the woman went her way and ate; and her facial expression wasn’t sad any more.

²⁰When the time had come, Hannah conceived, and bore a son; and she named him Samuel,^[a] saying, “Because I have asked him of Yahweh.”

It is OK to correct a false narrative. Allow your virtue and truth to shine even in dark situations. Peace showed up before the answer did. Hannah left her burden at the altar. She didn’t have the baby yet, but she had the “yes” in her spirit. Sometimes God changes your heart before He changes your situation to prove He is your source of joy.

She conceived and gave birth to Samuel, and later brought him back to serve the Lord, just as she had vowed (1 Samuel 1:19–28).

CST: Answered prayer often requires releasing what we prayed for.

Can you trust God enough to give back the blessing He gave you—time, talent, or even a person?

Dessert – The Song of Victory, 1 Sam 2:1–2

“Hannah prayed, and said, ‘My heart exults in Yahweh! My horn is exalted in Yahweh. My mouth is enlarged over my enemies, because I rejoice in your salvation. There is no one as holy as Yahweh, for there is no one besides you, nor is there any rock like our God.’

True praise flows from answered pain. Hannah’s song came from a place of long weeping and finally, breakthrough.

Reflection:

What song has your victory written for you? (It could be an actual song, a testimony, or a phrase you hold onto.)

To-Go Box

Hannah's story proves that barrenness—physical, emotional, or spiritual—is never the final word.

- Faith speaks life into empty places.
 - Honest prayer is better than fake peace.
 - God can give you peace in your heart before the answer shows up in your hands.
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Closing Prayer

“Lord, thank You for Hannah's story and for reminding us that You hear the cries we pray in secret.

Teach us to pour out our hearts honestly before You, to honor the vows we make, and to trust You with both our pain and our promises.

Where we feel barren or empty, speak life.

Where we have been misunderstood, let Your understanding surround us.

And when You answer, help us to give the glory—and even the blessing—back to You.

In Jesus' name, amen.”

Activity – Word Scramble: Hannah's Hope

Unscramble each word to reveal key truths from the lesson. (*Hints in parentheses*)

1. **NNAHHA** (her name) _____.
 2. **ULSAME** (the son she bore) _____.
 3. **EYARDP** (what she did earnestly) _____.
 4. **THFAI** (what God rewarded) _____.
 5. **LIHEFSI** (2 words, what she gave back to God) _____.
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Multiple Choice /Fill in the Blank

1. Elkanah was married to _____.

- a. Hannah and Peninnah
- b. Hannah and Phinehas
- c. Hophni and Peninnah
- d. None of the above

Answer.

2. Elkanah and his wives would go to sacrifice in _____ at the Lord of _____.

- a. Judah, Heaven's Armies
- b. Judah, Heaven's Angries
- c. Shiloh, Heaven's Armies
- d. Shiloh, Heaven's Angries

Answer.

3. A vow is a .

4. Hannah promised to never _____.

- (a) Fight Peninnah
- (b) Cut her child's hair
- (c) Lie again
- (d) Come to the temple drunk

Answer.

5. "Seeing her lips _____ but hearing no _____, he thought she had been _____."

Notes Page — Group Discussion & Personal Study
